MPA and Beyond

Joshua Behymer

Disability Services for Students

PADM 6001: Capstone Portfolio I

Dr. Matthew Mingus

March 17, 2025

MPA and Beyond

Aspiring for public service demands ongoing personal development and adherence to Master of Public Administration program core competencies. This paper analyzes future career objectives alongside the support provided by MPA programs to achieve these goals and outlines essential steps toward professional advancement. This analysis offers a broad perspective on capability enhancement for meaningful public service by linking individual experiences and skills with the program's structure.

Developing Specific Career Goals in Public Service

My professional ambition involves working as a policy analyst in either a governmental or nonprofit organization where I can contribute to the development and implementation of public policy revolving around the disability field. The mission of the MPA program focuses on ethical leadership and social equity backed by evidence-based decision-making which supports the development of this particular career goal. The core values of accountability, transparency, efficiency, equity, and effectiveness from the School of Public Affairs and Administration (SPAA) function as foundational principles steering my career trajectory (Denhardt & Denhardt, 2015).

The goal of the MPA program to develop public service leaders matches my aspiration to advance policies that improve community well-being. The program's focus on democratic principles and public service reflects my own dedication to ethical governance and citizen participation. I plan to apply these values to help create policies which address social inequities while supporting sustainable development (Witesman & Walters, 2014).

MPA Program and Career Progression

As a foundational program for public administration principles, organizational management and policy analysis, I will gain the necessary skills for advancing my career. My education in public finance along with strategic management and program evaluation courses will equip me with vital analytical and leadership abilities needed to develop and implement policies (Kettl, 2017). The combination of experiential learning with groupwork and networking opportunities within the program will help me apply theoretical knowledge effectively in practical scenarios.

Ethics and public accountability courses teach students how essential integrity and transparency are for good governance. Engaging with both faculty and peers allows me to gain multiple perspectives that deepen my understanding of policy problems and creative solutions. The program highlights the importance of data-driven decision-making because it provides essential tools for creating policies to solve intricate social problems (Bryson, 2018). Public administrators must evaluate wider policy consequences when promoting public interest which Lewis (2006) insists on as crucial. My role as a policy analyst requires these competencies to develop recommendations that properly reflect public interests.

Professional Background Expertise with Fundamental Competencies

Effective public administration depends on leadership which involves team management capabilities together with efficient resource distribution and the creation of an ethical organizational environment. Through my various roles in supported employment at nonprofit organizations, I gained

valuable experience leading teams and serving underrepresented populations while guaranteeing evidence-based practices. The MPA program will develop my leadership skills through organizational behavior and public sector management courses that teach team dynamics, strategic planning, and ethical decision-making.

A career in public administration requires a comprehensive understanding of policy formulation, implementation, and evaluation processes. My role as an Employment Services/Transitions Coordinator provided me with valuable experience in analyzing policies while preparing reports and engaging with community stakeholders. The MPA program develops these competencies through classes that teach policy analysis alongside legislative processes and program evaluation which prepare me to evaluate policy performance and support data-driven policy proposals.

In my current role as an Accommodation Specialist at Western Michigan University, I wear many hats to advance the mission and values of the Disability Services for Students (DSS) office. In my short six months as an Accommodation Specialist, I have presented to various groups including academic departments and specific courses to educate students and faculty on what resources are available through DSS. I have also had the opportunity to work with the Energy Efficient Autonomous Vehicle Lab to launch BroncoNav, a free, on-campus shuttle that can assist those with conditions that impact mobility, vision, and more to safely and efficiently navigate Western Michigan. I have also acted as the financial manager and direct supervisor for over a dozen office student staff and paid student aides. Through these experiences, I have been able to gain valuable experience in collaboration, financials, supervision, and more.

The ability to solve public service problems depends on analytical skills to evaluate data and detect patterns before suggesting practical solutions. My community advocacy background has developed my ability to evaluate social issues and devise strategic responses. Through the MPA program's data analytics and quantitative methods courses I will learn essential technical skills for performing thorough policy evaluations and enhancing program results. Piatak & Holt (2020) demonstrate how prosocial behaviors drive public service motivation and show why problem-solving should benefit overall societal welfare.

Public administrators need to maintain accountability and transparency while ensuring inclusivity when they adopt a public service perspective. My professional interactions with various communities strengthened my dedication to fair governance practices and equal policy application. The MPA program strengthens this perspective by offering classes on public ethics, civic engagement, and administrative law which will equip me to manage government decision-making complexities with a focus on serving the public interest. I plan to develop policies that improve social equity and community responsiveness by applying public service values in my work approach (Witesman & Walters, 2014).

Productive interactions with diverse workforces and citizens require effective communication to engage stakeholders and build public trust while presenting policy recommendations. My experience with public outreach programs where I directed workshops and community discussions helped me build strong communication skills. The MPA program builds upon my skills by offering courses in public communication and negotiation while also teaching stakeholder engagement which enables me to deliver complex information in a clear and persuasive manner.

Pursuing Continuous Self-Improvement

Through continuous professional development inside and outside my MPA program, I aim to overcome perceived weaknesses and build upon my skills. I will actively pursue mentorship possibilities from seasoned policy analysts and public administrators to learn about industry best practices. By participating in public administration conferences and workshops, I will gain insights into new industry trends and expand my professional network.

I will improve my quantitative analysis capabilities through further education in statistics and data analytics courses. The growing importance of data analysis in policy development requires me to master analytical tools which will improve my policy evaluation capabilities (Agranoff, 2018). Hands-on experience in applying these skills to real-world issues comes from participation in research projects, policy think tanks, and various other opportunities that Western Michigan University can provide.

My final step will involve self-evaluation and gathering useful feedback from professors and peers to disclose areas that require improvement. I can establish a comprehensive skill set suitable for public service by utilizing my research and communication abilities in combination with improvements in quantitative analysis and leadership expertise.

Conclusion

To achieve success in public service, one must maintain ongoing professional development alongside a solid understanding of essential public administration skills. My career objectives' alignment with the MPA program's mission and values enables me to make valuable contributions to policy development and governance. The program provides me with essential skills and knowledge and my continuous self-improvement keeps me prepared to tackle public sector challenges effectively. My academic involvement combined with professional experiences and skill development enables me to handle public administration complexities and create lasting contributions to my field.

References

Agranoff, R. (2018). *Collaborative public management: New strategies for local governments*. Georgetown University Press.

Bryson, J. M. (2018). *Strategic planning for public and nonprofit organizations: A guide to strengthening and sustaining organizational achievement*. John Wiley & Sons.

Denhardt, J. V., & Denhardt, R. B. (2015). *The new public service: Serving, not steering*. Routledge.

Frederickson, H. G. (1997). *The spirit of public administration*. Jossey-Bass.

Kettl, D. F. (2017). *The transformation of governance: Public administration for twenty-first century America*. Johns Hopkins University Press.

Lewis, C. W. (2006). In pursuit of public interest. *Public Administration Review, 66*(5), 694–701. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-6210.2006.00634.x

Piatak, J. S., & Holt, S. B. (2020). Prosocial behaviors: Does prosocial behavior stem from altruism or public service motivation? *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory, 30*(3), 504–510. https://dx.doi.org/10.1093/jopart/muz041

Witesman, E., & Walters, L. (2014). Public service values: A novel methodology for investigating motivation factors within public service roles. *Public Administration, 92*(2), 375–405. https://doi.org/10.1111/padm.12000